



European colonization of North America. American Indians later fueled the growth of cattle herds with a newly acquired love of beef and leather.

Transatlantic foods

The “exchange” of animal foods between the Old and New Worlds was mainly one-sided, with Europe importing its domesticated animals into the Americas. The exchange of plant life, by contrast, ran both ways. The European colonists attempted to grow all the traditional Old World Crops in the Americas, with sugar cane, bananas, and lemons, for example, all doing well in the tropical climate. Grain crops such as wheat grew better in mountainous regions and later found perfect growing conditions in the temperate plains of North America. By the end of the 16th century, sugar cane was growing in huge amounts in the Caribbean, Peru, Brazil, and Mexico, with entire forests being cleared for its growth. Exported in the opposite direction were crops that changed the diets of much of Europe

and Asia, including corn, beans, potatoes, and tobacco. Potatoes were introduced across Europe between 1570 and 1600, and two centuries later they would be one of the most important crops of the Old World, alongside corn. Cacao (a base ingredient of chocolate) transformed European confectionery, while tobacco introduced a whole new pastime. Tomatoes became staples of Mediterranean cooking, while chili peppers introduced new spices to Old World palates.

Destruction and disease

This great exchange steadily transformed the world’s diets, but also had dramatic human consequences. Along with food, the Europeans also brought diseases that devastated indigenous populations, principally smallpox, measles, bubonic plague,

Potatoes and wheat

Wheat, an Old World crop, grows alongside potatoes in a hilly region of South America. Wheat needs cooler temperatures to grow, and the first attempts to grow the plants in the American tropics largely failed.

typhoid fever, scarlet fever, cholera, whooping cough, diphtheria, mumps, and (from Africa) malaria and yellow fever. The only major disease that possibly traveled in the opposite direction was syphilis, although many experts dispute its origins.

Compounding the horrors of disease were the social effects of Old World agriculture in a New World setting. Local communities were displaced to make room for grazing cattle, or were forced to labor on farms and plantations. New types of weeds choked native plants. Serious overgrazing problems occurred in places such as New Spain, with large areas

turned practically to desert, having been stripped of vegetation and suffering from soil erosion. For better or worse, the New World had imported much more than just plants and animals.

New cuisine

This Italian cookbook from 1622 was an effort to teach Italians how to cook the exotic foods arriving from the Americas, such as tomatoes.



The Great Exchange had far-reaching implications across the world, irrevocably changing the global ecosystem.

EXPORT OF TEA

Tea was first imported to the Dutch settlement of New Amsterdam in North America in 1650, and during the second half of the 17th century its popularity spread along the eastern seaboard. By the 19th century, **tea clippers were making regular tea runs from Europe to Boston, New York, and Philadelphia.**



TEA CLIPPER

CHANGED LIVES

In the late 1400s the native population of North and South America numbered around 40 million, but by the late 1700s that **figure had fallen by 70–90 percent**, mainly because of European-introduced diseases. The consequent collapse of the local workforce in the Americas contributed to the creation of the **transatlantic slave trade**, in which millions of Africans were forcibly shipped to the Americas to live and work on plantations **280–81 >>**



Plains horses

The introduction of horses had a profound effect on the history of the Americas. Horses had existed on these continents previously, but were hunted to extinction by 7000 BCE. Once American Indian nations of the plains (stretching from the Rocky Mountains to the Mississippi River) mastered the use of the horse, it transformed their way of life. They were now able to travel faster and farther than ever before, and their hunting efficiency increased exponentially.